

Expert Q&A;: How to Evaluate a Clinical Trial Invitation

Questions to ask before signing the consent form.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-19 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Questions to ask before signing the consent form.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]](#)[\(/conditions/rheumatoid-arthritis\)](#).
 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment.
 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.
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Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Current evidence from systematic reviews consistently highlights the importance of shared decision-making in healthcare, particularly when considering clinical trials. This means that patients and clinicians work together to make choices about care, taking into account the best available research evidence and the patient's individual values and preferences. Clinical guidelines from professional bodies also stress the ethical imperative of informed consent, ensuring participants fully understand the implications of joining a trial.

Randomised controlled trials, the gold standard for testing new interventions, rely on volunteers who are fully aware of what their participation entails. Reviews of trial participation emphasise that clarity of information, presented in an easy-to-understand way, is crucial for people to make a genuine choice. This includes understanding potential benefits, risks, and the commitment involved.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Assuming 'experimental' means 'better':** A new treatment is still unproven, even if it sounds promising. *Always ask about the current standard of care and how the experimental treatment compares.* * **Not asking about costs:** While trial participation itself shouldn't cost you money, travel or time off work might. *Clarify any potential indirect costs before you commit.* * **Feeling pressured to say yes:** You have the right to decline an invitation to a trial without affecting your ongoing care. *Take your time, discuss it with someone you trust, and only agree if you feel comfortable.* * **Not understanding the time commitment involved:** Some trials require frequent visits or lengthy appointments. *Ask for a clear schedule of appointments and procedures.* * **Forgetting you can withdraw:** You can leave a clinical trial at any time, for any reason, even if you've already started. *Remember this right and don't feel trapped.* * **Not clarifying who to contact with questions or problems:** You should have a clear point of contact during the trial. *Ensure you have the name and phone number of the research team member who can help you.*

When to Speak to a Clinician

If you've been invited to a clinical trial and have concerns, or if new symptoms develop during your participation, it's always wise to discuss them with your general practitioner, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist. They can offer an objective perspective and help you weigh your options or address any issues that arise.

* You're experiencing new or worsening pain after starting a trial. * You're unsure about the information you've been given about the trial. * You feel uncomfortable or pressured to continue participating. * You're developing side effects that weren't clearly explained. * Your general health changes in a way that might affect your trial participation.

Frequently Asked Questions

What kind of questions should I ask before joining a clinical trial?
You should ask about the purpose of the trial, what treatments are being studied, how long it will last, what's expected of you, and any potential risks or benefits. It's also helpful to ask about what happens after the trial ends.

Will participating in a clinical trial affect my regular medical care?
Generally, being in a clinical trial should complement your existing care, not replace it. However, some trials might require you to pause or change certain medications or treatments you're currently receiving. Always clarify how the trial might interact with your usual medical routine.

What happens if a clinical trial drug doesn't work for me, or I experience side effects? The research team will closely monitor you for any changes or side effects. If a treatment isn't working or causes significant problems, they will discuss your options with you, which may include stopping the trial treatment. You always have the right to withdraw from a trial if you wish.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about expert q&a;: how to evaluate a clinical trial invitation?

Short answer: Before joining a clinical trial, ask about its purpose, the treatments involved, and its duration. Inquire about expectations, potential risks and benefits, and what happens once the trial concludes. Ensure you understand how participation might affect your regular medical care and clarify who to contact with questions. You can withdraw from a trial at any time.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk